

only crib about the size of the keys comprising its last row—evidently; practicality has been compromised for a more appealing look. As with most Nokias, navigation holds no surprises or irritants in the 2600.

The Nokia 2600 and LG B2050 are phones that you will not be ashamed to use in your college or workplace. They may not look great, but they are certainly not cheap-looking either—from a distance, at least.

Many of us here at *Digit* found the B2050 'cute', while some just thought it was 'feminine'. Nothing wrong with that, of course. Up on closer inspection though, it does look and even feel very plastic, making the Nokia 2600 look better on the whole.

Rs 3,000 to Rs 4,000

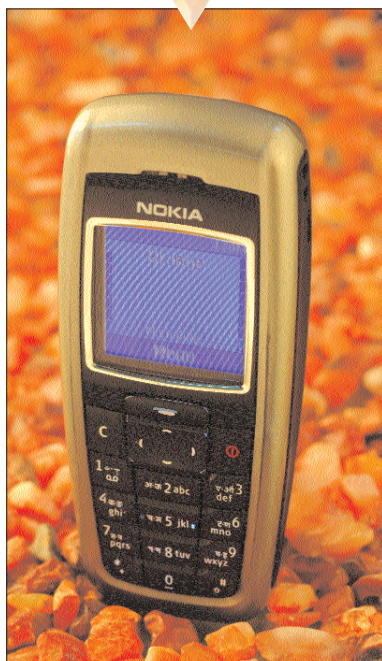
Next in line were Sony Ericsson's J100i and J220i, priced at around Rs 3,800. The J100i is as basic and barebones as the C139, which incidentally is a whole thousand rupees cheaper. And that says it all about the J100i. The J220i is the better of the two with a clearer screen and a more forgiving keypad. Its menu navigation is intuitive making this a good first phone to own. The navigation keys on the J100i and the J220i function as shortcuts to the alarm, phonebook and to the SMS compose box—accessing contacts and sending a message is literally a button away.

The LG B2070 is an avatar of the B2050 with an FM radio. Radio reception is good outdoors but can be a concern in a closed environment. Its stereo headphones, which double as a microphone, reproduce vocals very well but not bass.

In the sub Rs 4,000 range, the Nokia 1600 tried a new, and unusual, keypad design, but lost points on ergonomics because of its—typing an SMS is an ordeal on this phone. On the brighter side, its clear white backlight and good loud-speaker make up for the odd keypad.

The J100i and the J220i are dual-toned with soft colours that blend in well with each other, but alas, the plastic feel remains. The B2070 shares its look with its cousin, the B2050.

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Nokia 2600-Value for Money

Rs 4,000 to Rs 5,500

Joining the FM bandwagon is the Sony Ericsson's J230i at the higher end of this budget segment. The J230i is an avatar of the J220i, packed with an FM radio. Like the other phones we got in this class, the keypad of the J230i feels a bit dead and takes the joy away.

Wrapping up this budget segment at the Rs 5,000 border, are the Nokia 3120 and 6030 phones. The 6030 offers a generous ten fields per entry in its 250 contacts capable phonebook. The 3120 gives you 256 contacts with four fields per contact. There is little else to distinguish these two phones which are separated by about Rs 400. The 6030 has a 65k colour screen while the 3120 has to make do with a screen offering only 4k colours, though the difference in clarity is not very noticeable. On the 6030, we were at ease with its large softkeys, but did feel that the number keys could have been bigger for the SMS junkies amongst us.

The SE J230i offered the best audio quality—through its earphones as well as its speaker. The good news continues with the FM reception: the J230i fares much better than the LG B2070, both in terms of the FM audio quality and the ability to pick up signals indoors. On an otherwise white and silver body, there are two careless spots of orange vying for your attention. This might good if you want your phone to generate curious looks in college, but not quite so in a conference room. The 6030 is a typical block look Nokia—unassuming, simple with no make up. The most graceful of this lot is the 3120 which can pass off as an executive's phone. Dual-tones that work well, good fit and finish—all make it a neat looking package.

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Nokia 6030 - FM radio adds value

Conclusion

Barring FM radio on the Nokia 6030, LG B2070 and the Sony Ericsson J230i, there were no models to go gaga over. With hardly any price differences and features separating the phones in each price-band, our job was not easy. Giving a fair weightage to the price did not mean that the least priced phones

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